

LECTURE 6 THE DRUIDS

There is no class of Celtic society that so intrigued the classical world as the Druids. The writings of the Greek and Romans concerning Druids, with all their misinterpretations and misconceptions, have become the basis for a veritable "druid industry" which was created from the 17th century and has lasted into modern times.

Celtic society, as we have seen, was based on the caste system with the intellectual class, or druids being second after kings. This class encompassed all the professional occupations--judges, doctors, historians, philosophers, story-tellers, bards, astronomers and astrologers as well as the priestly orders who mediated with the deities.

As with most things Celtic, it is the Greek writers who first record the name *Druidae* about the second century BC.

The name is clearly of Celtic origin altho linguists still battle over its exact meaning. There is popular support for the claims of Strabo and Pliny the Elder that the word was cognate with the Greek word *drus*, an oak.

The Indo-European root is also found in Irish and Welsh and it is thought the word might be DRU VID or Oak Knowledge. bottom line, is the idea that Druid means "those whose knowledge is great."

LOCATIONS:

The classical texts referred to Druids only in Gaul and Britain. Druids are not mentioned as existing among the many Celtic groups including the Cisalpine, the Iberian Celts, Eastern Celts or the Galatian Celts.

Neither are the druids mentioned in connection with Ireland, tho, of course, we know that they existed there from subsequent native literature.

Does this mean that the Druids were confined to the Gaulish and British Celts? The answer to this question depends on what our interpretation of the function of a Druid is.

If one accepts that the Druids were an intellectual caste or class, as Caesar lets slip, comparing them rightly with the Brahmins of Hindu society, then we may argue that Druids or their class equivalent appeared throughout Celtic society.

That the druids encompassed several intellectual fields may certainly be accepted from the evidence.

TITLES:

The Celts did have specific names for their priests, such as *gutuatri* which means "speakers"(to the gods) . The Gutuatri are known from inscriptions and a reference to a *gutuatros* put to death by Caesar in The Gallic War.

Other words are also used to describe priestly functions, such as Antistites, sacerdotes and semnotheoi, which is used as a synonym for a druid, but perhaps is only describing a particular Druidic priestly function.

Several Greek and Latin writers speak of Druidesses and the existence of such female druids is certainly confirmed by native Celtic sources, although the classical sources seem to place more emphasis on male Druids (of course).

SOURCES FOR THE DRUIDS

The earliest sources on the Druids, written by Greeks, are known only by being quoted from later writers from Alexandria, Egypt. These sources are very respectful of the druids and the Celts in general. Unfortunately, the way the druids have become more popularly known is thru the anti-Celtic writings of the Romans.

Again, it is POSEIDONIOS (c.135-c.50 BC) of Apamea, Syria who was used as the major source material on the Celts of Gaul by all our main pro-Roman writers on the druids.

It is believed that the original writing of Poseidonios was

already lost by the first century BC and that a greek writer Timagenes was the intermediary who passed it on by quoting large sections of it.

Those quotations are substantially the passages used by all other writers.

STRABO in his *Geographia* , says:

...The Druids, in addition to the science of nature, study also moral philosophy. They are believed to be the most just of men, and are therefore entrusted with the decision of cases affecting either individuals or the public; indeed in former times they arbitrated in war and brought to a standstill the opponents when about to draw up in line of battle; and murder cases have been mostly entrusted to their decision. . These men, as well as other authorities, have pronounced that men's souls and the universe are indestructible, although at times fire or water may (temporarily) prevail.

Strabo and others who quote Timagenes as the authority on Druids. They divide the Gaulish intellectual class into Bards, Vates and Druids. 'the Bards re singers and poets; the Vates interpreters of sacrifice and natural philosophers. . .' We find some confirmation of this when ther insular Celtic records cite the same classes of intellectuals in Ireland. -Druí, Bard and Fili.

Timagenes can only be quoted from other writers because he got himself into disfavor with the emperor and burnt his works before he left Rome. However, he is quoted extensively by other writers, such as Ammianus Marcellinus (c.330-395 AD), a Greek from Antioch who mentions that the Druids had an organization, a corporate life.

Caesar also says that they were a highly organized fraternity:

All the Druids are under one leader, whom they hold in the highest respect. On his death, if any one of the rest is of outstanding merit, he succeeds to the vacant place; if several have equal claims, the Druids usually decide the election by voting, though sometimes they actually fight it out. On a

fixed date in each year they hold a session in a consecrated spot in the country of the Carnutes, which is supposed to be the centre of Gaul.

The CARNUTES were the Celtic tribe in the region between the Seine and the Loire. The chief town of the tribe was Cennabum which is present day Orleans.

Strabo and others are obviously deriving their information from a common source as they quote it extensively. However, Strabo's work was a pointed attack on the Celts which was written as a justification for the conquest of Gaul and subsequent attempts to suppress the Celtic intelligentsia and their centers of learning.

JULIUS CAESAR, at least, is quite clear on who the Druids are. He calls them 'an intellectual class.'

The druids officiate at the worship of the gods, regulate public and private sacrifices (rituals), and give rulings on all religious questions. Large numbers of young men flock to them for instruction, and they are held in great honor by the people.

They act as judges in practically all disputes, whether between tribes or between individuals; when any crime is committed or a murder takes place, or a dispute arises, about an inheritance or a boundary, it is they who adjudicate the matter and appoint the compensation to be paid and received by the parties concerned. Any individual or tribe failing to accept their award is banned from taking part in sacrifice (religious service). The heaviest punishment that can be inflicted upon a Gaul.

Those who are under such a ban are regarded as impious criminals. Everyone shuns them and avoids going near or speaking to them, for fear of taking some harm by contact with what is unclean; If they appear as plaintiffs, justice is denied them and they are excluded from a share in any honor.

Because of the special position of the Druids in society, Caesar informs us:

The Druids are exempt from military service and do not pay taxes like other citizens. These important privileges are naturally attractive; many

present

themselves of their own accord to become students of Druidism, and others are sent by their parents and relatives. It is said that these people have to memorize a great number of verses --so many that some spend twenty years at their studies.

The druidic doctrine is believed to have been found existing in Britain and thence imported into Gaul; even today those who want to make a profound study of it generally go to Britain for the purpose.

This seems to imply that there were colleges and schools in Britain and, indeed, in Ireland

Caesar's description of the Druids dwells mostly on their religious aspect and so, to the undiscerning reader, they appear simply as a priesthood.

We have already mentioned the fact that the Druids were forbidden to commit their teachings to writing. Caesar also points out:

A lesson which they take particular pains to inculcate is that the soul does not perish, but after death passes from one body to another; they think that this is the best incentive to bravery, because it teaches men to disregard the terrors of death.

He continues:

They also hold long discussions about the heavenly bodies and their movements, the size of the universe and of the earth, the physical constitutions of the world, and the powers and properties of the gods; and they instruct the young men in all these subjects.

We will deal with Cosmology later on.

PLINY THE ELDER was of a family of Roman colonists who settled among the Celts of the Po Valley after their conquest. Pliny himself was fascinated by magic and gives one of the most complete accounts of the Druids as natural scientists, doctors of medicine and magicians.

Pliny was the first writer to bring the oak grove into our popular picture of the Druids, as well as mistletoe.

"The Druids--for so they (the celts) call their magi--hold nothing more sacred than the mistletoe and the tree on which it grows provided that it is an oak. They choose the oak to form groves, and they do not perform any religious rites without its foliage, so that it can be seen that the Druids are so called from the Greek word.

Pliny thus opened the floodgates for writers to conjure images of Druids and oaks and mistletoe. Pliny becomes lyrical on the Druids and oaks:

Anything growing on those trees they regard as sent from heaven and a sign that this tree has been chosen by the gods themselves. Mistletoe is, however, very rarely found, and when found, it is gathered with great ceremony and especially on the sixth day of the moon. . .they prepare a ritual sacrifice and feast under the tree, and lead up two white bulls whose horns are bound for the first time on this occasion.

A priest attired in a white vestment ascends the tree and with a golden pruning hook cuts the mistletoe which is caught in a white cloth. Then next they sacrifice the victims praying that the gods will make their gifts propitious to those to whom they have given it. They believe that if given in drink the mistletoe will give fecundity to any barren animal, and that it is predominant against all poisons.

This has been described by scholar Nora Chadwick as a 'picturesque fantasia' ranking with other mythological stories about real people. It has become a classic of universal popular knowledge but w/o substance.

CORNELIUS TACITUS gives us invaluable information on Druids as historians in his *Histories* he speaks of attempts to stir up insurrection in Gaul in 69 AD.

The Gauls began to breath new life and vigour, persuaded that the Roman armies, wherever stationed, were broken and dispirited. A rumor was current among them, and universally believed, that ratians and Sarmatians had laid siege to the encampments in a couple provinces. Affairs in Britain were supposed to be in no better situation. Above all, the destruction of the Capitol announced the approaching fate of the Roman Empire.

The Druids, in their wild enthusiasm, sang their oracular songs , in

which they taught that, when Rome was formerly sacked by the Celts, the mansion of Jupiter being left entire, the commonwealth survived that dreadful shock; but the calamity of fire, which had lately happened, was a denunciation from heaven in consequence of which, power and dominion were to circulate round the world, and the nations on their side of the Alps were in their turn to become masters of the world.

The fact that in 69 AD the Druid historians of Gaul retained a knowledge of the defeat and occupation of Rome in 390 BC is fascinating and shows clearly how well the oral traditions were kept by the Celts.

What this means is that more attention should be paid to the histories of Ireland dealing with ancient times, tho not written until the Christian period. Oral tradition seems to have been just as reliable as written tradition for the Celts, as it is for many native peoples.

In 54 AD the Emperor Claudius officially prohibited the Druids by law. In order to conquer any people and absorb them, you first have to get rid of their intellectuals and destroy their cultural knowledge.

It is only later that a group of Greek scholars, mainly from the school of Alexandria, began to examine older Greek sources and develop a more balanced view. This group was mainly concerned with gathering sources and traditions and meticulously citing their authorities, creating encyclopedias rather than producing first hand observations.

Some, Professor Stuart Piggott for example, have tended to dismiss these Alexandrian texts in favor of the Roman saying that the Alexandrian texts idealized the Druids. However, Rome tried to denigrate them. The truth is probably somewhere in between.

DION CHRYSOSTOM (1st cent. AD) was the first figure of importance in the new school and he had conducted "field work", having come from Bithynia next to Galatia and travelled widely

there among the Celts.

He is highly respectful of the Druids whom he compares, accurately, with the Brahmins of Hindu society. He mentions their intellectual attainments, crediting them with advances in branches of ancient wisdom, and describes their political influence saying:

The Celts appointed Druids, who likewise were versed in the art of seers and other forms of wisdom, without whom the kings were not permitted to adopt or plan any course, so that in fact it was these who ruled and the kings became their subordinates and instruments of their judgement, while themselves seated on gholden thrones, and dwelling in great houses and being sumptuously feasted.

It is from the Alexandrian school that we first hear of the similarities between the Druid's teaching and Pythagoras'. AS said before, it is still unclear who influenced whom.

CONCLUSION:

By the time the Celts started to commit their knowledge to writing in their own tongue, not only had their world become very much reduced in size but they had become Christian.

The very act of becoming Christian was the means by which the Druid proscription on committing their knowledge to writing was lifted. Yet, at the same time, the general Christian attitude was to depict their pagan forefathers, especially the Druids, in as biased a manner as the pro-Roman writers had done, but for different reasons.

In the emerging Christian world, the Druids were generally portrayed as opponents to Christianity, upholders of the ancient religion, and thus were relegated to the role of shamans, magicians and 'witch doctors' although the degree of prejudice varied from writer to writer.

Among the early Irish scribes there were a sufficient number of writers who were still respectful of the Druids as an intellectual class and held the view that the early Celtic saints were Druids, members of that class.

As Christianity began to absorb the Celtic peoples, the Druids, both male and female, were the first to encompass the new learning. The fact that many of the early Celtic saints were druids or the children of Druids is significant.

Christianity did not fight a battle with the Druids; the Druids absorbed the new religion and were the first to start promulgating its beliefs, thus giving rise to the phenomenon we now call the Celtic church. We will deal with celtic Christianity later.

Unfortunately, during the 17th century, in Germany, France and England, romantics began to re-invent the Druids having, in the wake of the Renaissance, discovered references to them in works such as Caesar's

Today there are countless 'Druidic movements' throughout the world, none of which has anything to do with the Druids of reality; with the Druids who were the intellectual class of Celtic society in the ancient world.

CELTIC COSMOLOGY

Cosmology means an orderly way to conceive of the universe. In other words, how does the universe work and affect us.

The Celts had a reputation for their speculations from the stars. As one writer, Pomponius Mela (c. 41 AD) said

They have, further, their eloquence and their Druids, teachers of wisdom, who profess to know the greatness and shape of the earth and the universe and the motion of the heavens and of the stars and what is the will of the Gods.

Others mention that the Celts foretold the future from the stars by ciphers and numbers much like the Pythagoreans.

From the beginning of time human beings have tried to explain natural phenomena. Early societies noticed that the sun and moon together affected the tides and the sun regulated the seasons.

They also noticed that the motions of the moon could in some cases affect men and women and their mental attitudes. From this, there developed the idea that 'stars' also influenced people and events on earth.

Astrology and Astronomy were in fact together in peoples minds until the 17th century and the 'Age of Reason' when they went separate ways. Historians argue that they both had their beginning in Babylon and made its way into Europe thru Greece.

However, we find that astrology did not have its 'birth' in any one place and that all societies in whatever part of the world, evolved a system of cosmology, of looking at the heavens, and all developed a theory. The Celts were no exception so how did they view the heavens and relate to them?

CALENDAR

The fact that the Celts developed a calendrical system shows their competence in astronomy. The earliest surviving celtic

calander, the COLIGNY CALENDAR, dates to the 1st century BC and was discovered in 1897. The language in it is Gaulish Celtic and when it was analyzed, it confirmed Pliny the elder's comment about the Celtic thrity-year calendrical cycle.

Dr. Heinrich Zimmer, a leading Celtic scholar as well as a Sanskrit expert, studied the calendar within months of its discovery and was the first to point out that it had many parallels to Vedic calendrical computations.

This parallel with the Vedic system has been reinforced by recent studies. Dr. Garrett Olmsted in a book in German published in 1992 demonstrated by astronomical calculus that the calendar must have originally been computed in 1100 BC.

Thus, we have a Celtic calendar that dates back three millenia, endorsing the comments of the classical sources regarding the long tradition and sophistication of Celtic Canendrical methodology.

Far more work needs to be done in comparisons with early Vedic records as well as Hittite records, written in cuneiform on clay tablets dating from about 1900-1400 BC. By far these are the earliest example of an Indo-European language being committed to literature.

This material is rich in cosmological records and as a relative of both Celtic and Sanskrit, its cosmological philosophies provide fascinating comparisons.

THE COLIGNY CALENDAR is far more elaborate than the rudimentary Julian calendar and incorporates a highly sophisticated five year synchronisation of lunar year with the solar year. It is a masterpiece of calendrical calculation.

Against the months are subscribed the letters MAT or ANM meaning bad or good. The months are named in Gualish Celtic with Giamon as the midwinter month and Samon as the midsummer month.

there is a black half of the year and a light half of the year and in between the two halves is the Gaulish Celtic word *atenvix*, which translates as 'renewal', as in the old Irish word *athnugud*.

There are sixty two consecutive months in the calendar, divided into periods of twenty nine or thirty nights each. In celtic fashion, the calendar reckons periods by nights. as Caesar observed.

They count periods of time not by the number of days but by the number of nights; and in reckoning birthdays and the new moon and the new year their unit of reckoning is the night followed by the day.'

Pliny implies, probably correctly, that it was by the moon that the Celts measured their months and years and also 'ages' or thirty year periods, presumably the thirty years was regarded as a generation.

In this regard they and the vedic calendar are very close, with the same 30 year cycle and an extra month every 5 years.

It is clear that by the first century AD the majority of the Continental Celtic peoples had adopted the new forms of astronomy and astrology that were used in the Graeco - Roman world.

These had emerged from Babylon into Greece and thence to Rome. The older methods used by the Celts, once common to Indo-European society, were swept away.

ASTROLOGY/ASTRONOMY

Pliny refers to the reputation of Gaulish Celtic astrologers in the first century AD. But by the time they emerge into historical scrutiny they were using the Graeco-Roman forms. There were several astrologers of note in the first few centuries AD

It is from the sixth century AD that we begin to find a wealth of written evidence from the insular Celts concerning cosmology. From it we find that Irish cosmology falls into four historic

phases.

first, the pre-Christian phase, of which we have only fragmentary knowledge and indicates that the Celts shared the Indo-European knowledge of numerology, astronomy and astrology which emerges in the Vedas.

then, as the Celtic world entered the Christian period, the new Graeco-latin learning arrived from Babylonia. In the earliest Irish evidence, the cosmology shows the influence of an Alexandrian, Claudius Ptolemy (2nd cent. AD) whose teachings on astronomy and astrology were accepted until the arrival of Arabic influences and the work of Copernicus.

In Britain there is a sculpture showing the zodiacal signs dating from as early as the 3rd cent. AD. It was found in the northernmost edge of Roman influence, in Housesteads.

in 655 AD and Irish astronomer named AIBHISTIN was the earliest medieval writer to discuss the relationship of the tides to the phases of the moon. He is also the first Christian writer to proclaim that the Three wise men (and it was the Irish who decided there were three) in the Gospel of Matthew were astrologers.

It appears that, following the introduction of Christianity into Ireland, when the great ecclesiastical universities displaced the bardic colleges, the latter became the centers for studying the the heavens.

Through the Medieval period, astronomical observation was a sustained activity in many Irish monastic schools. A comparison of the Irish records with Continental records shows that the former tend to be trustworthy while the continental records are often badly transcribed, wrongly recorded and inaccurate.

Between 627 AD and 1133 some thirty astronomical observations were found to exist only in Irish records. There was no other European textual evidence for these events found, but they corresponded to many non-european sightings, from

India, China and Japan, and when calibrated the Irish records were in precise accord.

As one example, in 1054 AD the Italians recorded what appeared to be a supernova in the Crab Nebula dating it April 19, 1054--significantly the date of the death of Pope Leo I.

But, the Irish sources dated it nearly eight weeks later. Who was right? The Irish date corresponded with the Chinese and Japanese observations precisely. It seems the Italians had adjusted the date to coincide with Pope Leo's death.

The system used by the Irish astronomers and astrologers changed again in the eleventh century AD when new Arabic learning, mathematics, medicine, astronomy and astrology entered Europe through such universities as Montpellier and Bologna.

Irish professors teaching there at the time brought the new knowledge back to Ireland. There is a rich source of manuscript texts and books about astronomy and astrology written in Irish between the 12th and 16th centuries AD, including translations from Arabic, Greek and Latin as well as native texts. However, by this time the ancient ideas had more or less been filtered out.

CONCLUSION:

The identification of parallels between Celtic cosmology, predominantly surviving in early Irish texts, and the cosmology of the Indian Vedas is important. If, as some western authorities claim, the Vedas had really borrowed wholesale from the Babylonians via Greece at the time of Alexander the Great's invasion, then we should not be able to see similarities between old Irish and Sanskrit in the fields of linguistic, cosmology and numerology.

Why? because Babylonian culture would have introduced a completely alien element into Vedic culture and there would be no parallels in the Celtic Culture.

Babylonian culture derives from two non-Indo-European

sources: Sumerian, the oldest recorded language dating to 3500 BC and unrelated to any other known group, and Hamito-Semitic. Certainly we could not expect parallel cognitive terms and ideas to exist in two diverse branches of Indo-European culture if one of them had been heavily influenced by non-Indo-European learning.

This area of Celtic studies is only just opening up to scholarship; through it we may discover not only the realities of Celtic cosmology but also how the original Indo-Europeans viewed their universe.

Do Merlin from legends of The Isles - 26 min
start by 8:30

~~The Celts~~ #13 - a pagan trinity
to Celtic Xianity